its schools who distinguished themselves in the sciences and trained them as paramedics who were then embedded with Lashkar militants fighting there.

As impressive as its medical services were, MDI's school system easily surpassed them. The first two Al-Dawa schools were established in 1994: one in Lahore and the other at Muridke.[20] More schools opened rapidly throughout the country. Their success was a result of the quality and breadth of instruction provided, as well as the group's willingness to subsidize tuition for those who could not afford it. According to a 2010 study by the Brookings Institute, Pakistan's education sector has been declining for several decades and access to quality education remains low. The primary barrier to education is a shortage of government or public schools, and many parents have turned to private schools rather than enroll their children in madaris where the curriculum is limited to predominantly Islamic studies.[21] Because private schools are often off limits for financial reasons, Al-Dawa schools can fill this void. MDI had established 127 schools with 15,000 students and 800 teachers across the country by 2001. There was even a procedure in place for non-MDI members to establish an Al-Dawa school in their area.[22]

Lashkar's provincial chief in Balochistan, Saeed Athar, summed up the rationale for focusing on education when he said, 'Children are like clean blackboards—whatever you write will leave a mark on them forever.'[23] According to its website, Al-Dawa Schools were set up to help realize the group's overarching mission as outlined earlier: 'Jihad in the way of Allah preaching the true religion and the training of [a] new generation on Islamic lines'. The group detailed the specific objectives and policies of Al-Dawa System of Schools as:

> – To purify the society through the teachings of the Quran and the Sunnah;
> – To prepare the individuals for the proclamation of the faith of Islam;
> – To connect the religions and contemporary knowledge;
> – To build up the students character to remove the destructive effects of secular education;
> – To enable the students to play an active role in the society;
> – To prepare sensible and responsible individuals; and
> – To prepare the creative and independent minds.[24]